On Our Own

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Mature

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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by Faded_Glory

Summary

(A companion piece to Tapestry of Time) With the Death of Louis, Red Squad has completely fractured. Each one of them is struggling with the loss in different ways, none of them very healthy. So Strike Team A sets out to build a monument to their fallen bunkmates. A place for them all to grieve, pay their respects to their loved ones and try to heal from witnessing yet another life cut to short.

Notes

Hi! I hope you guys enjoy this side series, I hope to delve into some side stories that link into the main story as I go. As always love to read your comments, feedback is very appreciated. This is a collection of short stories set before, between and after my main series 'Tapestry of Time.' I suggest you read, Kingdom of Ash, Kingdom of Stars and Kingdom of Blood before.

Seeking Solace

Day One

The skiff started out running well…perhaps that was just positive thinking on Adora's part. It was salvaged from the scrapyard, so none of others had very high expectations from it. The hull was rusted out, with a huge hole in the deck near the bow. Dented and partially caved in along the back port side. With barely any kind of safety railing to speak of, along the sides. No doubt that this hunk of junk had been in a major collision out on the battlefield. The sail was a patched together tarp, sewn together with suturing thread. Pilfered from the medical wing of the barracks. No doubt, Max's work. Levi was the grease monkey of the two.

The engine hummed, mostly…hiccupped a bit…then began choking on the reclaimed fuel. The two had naturally siphoned from fuel tanks from other wrecked war machines out in the scrapyard. But it kept going. For at least about an hour or so out into the wasteland beyond the fortress. Before it was sputtering and limping, with a dark cloud of smoke billowing out the back. Catra was perched on the back engine housing. Just behind Adora who was at the rudder. The magicat wasn't surprised by their inevitable misfortune. This was par for the course in regards to Levi and Max's, ineptitude. She never had much faith in them anyway. The magicat sneered in disgust at the dark smoke, as it stung her sensitive nose. As a sharp explosion rocked the ship. Catra yelped in fright, leaping from the engine manifold to the main mast. Ears pinned back, head ringing, her tail puffed up to twice its size. As a caustic cloud expanded out from the back thrusters. The thrusters once a vivid green glow flickered and went out. As the skiff lurched to a sudden and jarring halt. Sending Kyle who had been sitting on the bow, head over heels over the open front and landing in a heap. Face first into the dirt

with his ass in the air, like the absolute uncoordinated doofus that he was.

"Seriously Kyle!" Catra cackled, from her perch atop the central mast of the main sail. Thoroughly entertained by Kyle's spectacular wipeout.

Lonnie and Rogelio were quick to leap overboard and help him back to his feet. Sharing his weight between them, as they slung his limp arms over their shoulder. Kyle was stunned and barely lucid from hitting the ground so hard…on his face. His blonde mop of hair was dusted with dirt and his nose had a good scrap along the bridge. Blood beading and rolling down the contours of his cheeks.

Kyle merely smiled drunkenly up at Catra and offered her a thumbs up.

Which only made Catra laugh harder at his expense.

Adora merely groaned resigned to the inevitable, dropping the rudder pole and slinging her pack over her shoulder. Before hopping over the side. Levi and Max loved to tinker with the junk in the scrapyard. Novice tech master's who were self taught, their machines had never been very reliable. So breaking down in the middle of nowhere had been par for the course.

"Guess we're walking from now on." Adora stated, looking to Lonnie to lead them. As this little expedition had been her idea. Lonnie glanced around the barren landscape trying to get her bearings. Rogelio eased the weight of Kyle from her shoulder and onto his own. Slinging the blonde boy over his back like a back pack. Then Lonnie promptly left Rogelio's side. Climbing back up into the skiff, grabbed her pack and rummaged inside, pulling out her metal compass.

The day moon was high overhead, beating down upon the small troop of horde recruits. With an almost violent relentlessness that

left the humans soaking in sweat Fighting the urge to down their canteen’s, as the red dust kicked up by the rough wind. That was scouring the barren landscape in sudden gusts. Irritated their eyes, forcing them to squint and shield themselves with their arms. Their throats were soon scratchy and dry, their bodies caked in dirt. Rogelio enjoyed the heat, a sheen of moisture coating his green scales. This arid climate seemed to be his natural habitat. The dirt coating his body welcomed protection against the glare of the Day Moon. Catra, who was incapable of sweating was left panting and horribly uncomfortable in her fur. She was overheated and coated in fine dust that clung and clumped in her fur. Making her scratch incessantly as they marched.

They moved in a diamond formation. With Lonnie at the forward point, Adora on the left and Catra on the right, with Rogelio carrying Kyle piggyback at the rear. His own pack slung over his chest to compensate for Kyle’s dead weight. Kyle who had managed to come to his senses within the hour after their skiff breakdown. Had attempted to walk on his own. Only to manage to twist his ankle about an hour ago, by not paying attention to where he was walking. Locking his foot into a rodent hole and toppling over himself due to his momentum. Squealing in both fright and sudden pain, as he crumpled to the ground in perfect Kyle fashion. This time Catra was far too miserable to appreciate Kyle's ineptitude. Rolling her eyes and growling in irritation instead of laughing.

They were all focusing on keeping up to Lonnie's brisk pace. Rogelio’s heavy steps had turned into a plodding shuffle, with the added weight upon his back. Adora kept her eye’s on a swivel, taking in the barren, lifeless wasteland of endless dirt and dead grass. They had left the toxic green sludge of what remained of a branch of the Wailing River, a few hours back. With no real landmarks now, to guide them but the crude map Lonnie had made on a scrap of paper. Which were just vague memories of the

route the transport had traveled from the Serpentine Straight to the Fortress. When she was just a foundling, to lead them.

Adora at this point, did not have a whole lot of trust that Lonnie was not leading them into the wasteland to die. So she kept searching for any means of survival. They would need shelter come nightfall and when their ration's ran out they would need a clean water source at least. Finding food would be a luxury out here in this empty dust bowl. But they could survive for a few weeks, as long as they have water…

She kept looking over her shoulder, at the dark peaks of the Whispering Woods in the far off distance. It was due west of their current position…going into the woods was not ideal. It was dangerous to go inside that forest, as it would swallow them whole and no doubt lead them all to their deaths. The Woods did not like the Horde…that was just facts. But if they became desperate, she would lead them there, they had a better chance of finding water in there than out here. So she kept track of what direction it lay.

"Where the hell are you taking us!" Catra shouted, flapping her arms in frustration. Before pulling her mask off her forehead, to fan her face.

"To the Sea, Cat." Lonnie commented in a low growl.

"I don't see any water, Lonnie. Just fucking nothing, all around us!" Catra shot back, placing her mask back on in a huff.

"Look, it could take us a few days to get there. But I know where I'm going!" Lonnie shouted back over her shoulder, increasing her speed.

Catra snarled, stomping her bare feet as the pace picked up.

As the Day Moon set, painting the sky in a glowing fiery hue. They finally stopped to make camp…in a large divot in the middle of

this barren, lifeless wasteland.

Unrolling their sleeping bags in the shallow hole in the ground.

Exhausted, their bodies depleted in every way. Rogelio, checked on Kyle's swollen ankle. Rewrapping the bandage and tenderly, tucking him into his sleeping bag. Kyle remained quiet, refusing to make even the smallest sound of discomfort. He was ashamed of himself and needed to show everyone how strong and unaffected he was by the pain. While Lonnie flopped down on her own sleeping bag beside him. Offering him a comforting pat on the shoulder.

Kyle merely grunted an acknowledgment, scowling up to the dull gray sky. As night slowly began to fall around them.

"We should start a campfire." Adora offered, rummaging through her pack to pull out ration bars for everyone.

"With what!" Catra exploded, having perched herself up on the dusty lip of the divot. She was curled up over her knees, ears pinned back and tail thumping angrily. Sending up a cloud of dust to fall over her bunk mates below, every time her tail struck the ground.

Kyle sneezed and then whimpered at the sudden jolt to his sore ankle.

"Stop that!" Lonnie shouted back, hurling a dirt clod up at Catra.

Catra hissed and jumped back out of view as the dirt ball sailed past her shoulder

"Catra just get down here and settle in your sleeping bag." Adora ordered in exasperation, as she settled inside on her own.

"This was a stupid plan…we are going to die out here." Catra muttered, bitterly, conceding to Adora. Hopping down and burrowing into her sleeping bag with a huff. Curling herself deep inside and balling up at the sealed end. Adora rolled over, bracing

her chin in a cupped palm. Surveying the lump at the very end of the plastic green sack. Her soft blue eyes are heavy with concern. Then released a tired sigh, she reached out and lightly patted the mound of scared, angry magicat. Offering her a soft, reassurance that she was there and that it would turn out alright in the end. Adora would make sure of that.

Catra answered with a threateningly low growl at Adora's touch. Adora thinned her lips in annoyance then nodded with acceptance. Turning onto her back she settled down for the long, cold night ahead. Staring up at the dark, blank sky as a resigned numbness seeped into her heart. Their friendship had been rocky for months….hell years even. Catra had become reluctant over the years to show any kind of softness towards her when they were alone. Adora could not remember the last time Catra had responded kindly, when she had reached out silently for her comfort. Catra had become far more standoffish and prickly the closer to graduation they came. She was easy to rile up and lashed out at any little thing that pissed her off.

Adora was tired of trying to fix everything, trying to keep Catra out of trouble. When all she wanted to do was antagonize the squad, disregard both Shadow Weaver and Lazlo’s order’s. Generally just rebelling against every aspect of the system they were raised in. Eventually getting caught and punished for her poor attitude and lack of dedication. Then blaming everyone else for her misfortunes, as if they were the cause and not her poor decisions. It was a vicious cycle and Adora was honestly over it.

Adora awoke slowly, groggy and disoriented. Shivering as the cold night had seeped into her very bones. She was barely conscious, yet her anxiety was already biting deep in her chest. So she blindly patted the lump she felt tucked against her curled legs for reassurance. Catra had shuffled her sleeping bag up against her in the middle of the night. Her smaller, slighter frame huddled up against her legs. Perhaps for warmth, perhaps seeking comfort… or attempting to soothe Adora? Who must have been fighting in her sleep? This had been Catra’s way of showing she cared, initiating her affection on her own terms. A low, growling purr

vibrated from the lump and Adora smiled softly. Knowing that she was there, she was scared too and that they were together in this.

So nothing really bad was going to happen and that gave her hope.

Day two

They were up and marching well before dawn, headed in the same vague South-eastern direction. Heading across the same, endless flat terrain. Towards a barren and utterly lifeless horizon. The morning went by quietly. With Catra brooding and lagging far behind the rest. Rogelio had fashioned a crutch for Kylie out of his bow staff and a boot knife sheath. Lashing the sheath to the pole at an angle for a brace for his armpit. Using an extra tensor bandage from the med kit and a whole lot of duct tape. Now Kyle hobbled behind Rogelio like a lost puppy, while the lizard kin tossed his unsheathed knife from hand to hand as they walked. Totally at ease in the rising heat, infuriating Catra even more. Who had barely raised her head up to look around. Scowling at her plodding feet, flexing her toe claws into the dry, flaking clay. Getting just a little satisfaction, from the jagged scratches she left in her wake.

Adora marched next to Lonnie in the lead, glancing worriedly over her shoulder to the sad state of the rest of the squad. It had been only one day, but their morale, already poor from grief, was now absolutely abysmal.

"I think we should head back…" She offered quietly. "We'll figure out another way to pay our respects to our lost comrades." She just couldn't say it, couldn't admit that perhaps they were all dead? Bryson and Louis were the only ones confirmed dead. Tama, Ami and Arron had merely gone missing. So she still held

out hope she would meet them again. That hope was thin like translucently thin but still there. She couldn't deny the nagging suspicion that Shadow Weaver may have been lying to her. When she had said, Tama had been 'taken care of'…those words carried so much power now. Ever since the old woman had threatened Catra life back in the Black Garnet chamber, with those very same words…'That she would take care of her…herself.' Adora couldn't deny the fear and foreboding that had taken root inside of her at Tama's fate. After that terrible incident.

The fact that Staff Sergeant Lazlo had said more on Ami and Arron's disappearance other than they were just not coming back, raised alarm bells as well. Yet she never questioned, too scared to admit they may be dead. It was easier to just remain numb and not deal with the grief. Focus on her own goals…keep putting one boot in front of the other and move forward.

"NO!" Lonnie spat back at Adora's cowardly opinion to turn back. She barely remembered her life in the village, before the Horde. But finding a nice place to erect a monument to their fellow cadets was extremely important to her. She needed to do this! She needed to make peace with their loss so she could move on. She had been carrying the grief of their deaths for far too long. The guilt and sadness was like a slow poison. She knew the marker would be cathartic not just to her, but to the rest of the squad as well. A place they could all go, to remember them and heal.

"Lonnie...be reasonable?" Adora grumbled. "Kyle can't walk…"

Lonnie glanced over her shoulder, pointedly. "He's walking fine." she spat defensively.

Adora groaned and started walking backward to check on the rest of the squad.

Grimacing as she watched Kyle shuffling in the dirt, wearing a grimace of determined stone upon his pale face. Catra was sulking. She looked disheveled and miserable when she woke up

this morning. With her fur all matted and caked with dirt. She was so far behind now, she was a featureless blob in the distance.

"CATRA! Double Time!" Adora shouted at her in warning. Just to spite her, the magicat never increased her pace, she even slowed down, quickly falling even further behind.

Lonnie turned, expression firm and resolute with purpose. Pulling her homemade slingshot off her utility belt. She had built the slightly curved metal hilt and dual prongs from junk in the scrapyard. All their personal weapon's that they kept hidden on their person or under their pillows back in the bunk room. For protection in the barracks, when they were on their own after hours. Growing up Horde, meant you were always on your guard for an attack and you were always prepared to defend yourself and your bunkroom.

Flipping open a pouch on the same utility belt and arming a pellet. Cocking the leather sling made from a shredded pair of her combat boots and plastic medical tubing, stolen from the medic bay near the combat holo-room. Firing at Catra, with precision and speed. The makeshift bolt struck the dirt just to the left of Catra's slowly plodding feet.

Catra yelped and skipped sideways, offering Lonnie a heated glare of coming retribution.

"Catch up or your target practice!" Lonnie threatened, feeding and cocking another round and firing. She had no fear of Catra, she had grown up with her, trained with her and was capable of defending herself if the hybrid tried to fight her.

Catra yelped again and leapt away as another round struck the dirt inches away from her feet. Lunging forward on all fours quickly racing past them all. The Magicat made sure to flip Lonnie off as she took the lead.

"That's one way to motivate that stubborn brat." Adora smirked towards Lonnie.

Lonnie smiled wanly back. “We’re Horde, violence is our love language.”

Adora’s smile quickly evaporated…

Day Three

Three days in they knew to stop and find some cover to rest in before the Day moon got too high. The heat of the hot season could be unbearable back at the Fortress. Here in the open waste, with no natural protection from the wind, it was grueling to endure. Finding a bit of shade to wait out the hottest part of the day was a whole other dilemma.

Thankfully they had stumbled upon a dried out valley late that morning. Huddled in the shadow of an overhanging ridge along the edge of the canyon wall. Their cool reprieve was fragile and wouldn’t last all day, as the Day Moon moved across the sky. The shade would slowly evaporate. But hopefully by the time the shade faded it would be tolerable to travel onward. It was one stressor down, but Adora was still worried. Their canteen’s were low, several were already empty. They could survive for a while without ration bars but not fresh water.

Adora sat at the edge of the shade, staring out over the blinding glare of the cracked red clay out beyond their sanctuary. She had long since stuffed her red jacket in her pack. Her sleeveless white tank top, now a rusty brown from the blowing dirt. Her well muscled arms bare and now bronzed by the heat and endless dusting of the red clay that surrounded them. Glancing over her shoulder briefly, observing the downtrodden state of her strike team. They were her responsibility. She had to take care of them, make the hard calls if things didn’t improve.

Rogelio was tending to Kyle, as always when they stopped to rest. The lizard kin’s green scales had tinted orange, now that they

were coated in red dust. The lanky blonde was looking pale, more sallow and pasty then usual. A sheen of sweat always coating his face. His white and red training shirt was soaked and he was starting to have a very off putting sour smell. His ankle had swollen up to twice its size, the cold packs from the med kit had done nothing. To reduce the swelling in this humid heat. His ankle was now a disgusting black and blue color. Yet, he refused to admit that it may very well be broken.

Stating he wasn't in any real pain, putting on a brave face even though they all caught him squinting and heard him grunting as they marched. While he hobbled and then hopped on one leg.

This was turning out to be less of an adventure and more a forced march to their deaths…Adora was preparing to order them back. If they didn't find fresh water, soon. Then she would have no choice but to take over leadership of this expedition from Lonnie. By force if she had too. She was not relishing having to fight her. Defeating her in combat would be the easiest part, Lonnie was decent in hand to hand but Adora was ruthless when she needed to be. But that would exhaust them both even more and put their lives at risk. Due to further heat exhaustion and dehydration. The other option would be to discredit her efforts verbally by pulling rank, it would be humiliating and Lonnie would definitely carry a grudge. Which would then put a strain on their ability to be a cohesive strike team in the future. Neither was ideal, but she was resolved to do what was necessary to keep them alive.

"This place is as good as anywhere else!" Catra's harsh snarl, echoed from deeper in the shade. Adora scanned the recess of the nook they were hiding in, finding the feline hovering inches in front of Lonnie. Her long mane was flared, which meant her hackles were up. Claws fully extended as she flapped her arms in exasperation as she prowled around Lonnie. The shine of the metal of her mask had dulled from the elements. She had ripped her maroon legging off at the knees leaving her lower legs and feet bare. She had also torn off the lower half of her body suit just below her breasts. Revealing her toned stomach and curving hips. All in a desperate attempt to cool her overheated body. Her tan

fur had stained a rusty red from the dried clay in the air. Completely covering up the stripes on her arms and lower back. The darker fur, now making her blue and golden eyes even more striking and shining even more fiercely in half light of the shade.

Lonnie stood her ground, arms crossed and glaring down her nose at the shorter angry feline. Who was attempting to get in her face and intimidate her. Lonnie was covered in the fine red dust. Her clothes were caked with it, her normally black dread's now a copper color. The clay had deepened her dark skin, to a rich mocha.

"What are we going to use to make the marker? Dirt clods! " Lonnie cast an arm out to the big expanse of nothing beyond their bit of shade.

"I'll go find something!" Catra vowed, combing her claws through her hair in frustration. Before she stormed off, back into the unbearable heat, Angrily, pulling on the shoulder straps of her pack to tighten it to her back.

"Catra!" Adora shouted, when the feline stomped past her and out into the sun. Grabbing her pack off the ground and scrambling to her feet and racing after the magicat.

"Hot headed…furball." Lonnie groused, shoulder's hunched self consciously. She was feeling guilty and stressed. This was her mission and she was failing terribly.

"Catra, come back!" Adora shouted, as she charged across the open bluff of red clay. Boots skidding and sliding down the loose dirt of the hillside and down into a shallow ravine.

"Don't follow me!" Catra screamed back, picking up her pace.

"I kinda have no choice…I'm your squad leader and you are my responsibility. Whether you like it or not!" Adora explained, with an irritated breath.

Catra snarled, bearing her fangs as she spun around to confront her.

“If you can’t tell, we are not in the Fortress anymore. You’re stupid power trips, don’t mean a damn thing out here!”

“I am not power tripping.” Adora folded her arms across her chest, indignant.

Catra’s cruel, raspy laugh cut deep as she threw her head back spitefully.

“Keep telling yourself that, oh, Fearless Leader…whatever helps you sleep at night. “ She commented dryly, turning on her heel and striding away.

Adora groaned and jogged to catch up.

“You’ve been pissed at me for weeks! Just spit it out already!” She grabbed Catra 's shoulders and forced her to stop and face her.

At first Catra wouldn’t look at her, glaring at the ground with such unbridled hatred, as if it was the source of her grudge and not Adora.

“It’s nothing, I’m generally pissed off.” She deflected, with a huff.

“I am tired of you shutting me out.” Adora shook her sharply.

“Urgh….whatever…I need to find Lonnie a stick or something so she can carve it up, for her stupid grave marker thing. Then we can go home already!” Catra rolled Adora’s hands off her shoulder and pushed her away, harshly. Completely avoiding and shutting down Adora’s attempt to get her to talk. What good would it do anyway! Nothing would ever change, Catra had come to terms with that.

Adora groaned and rolled her eyes in annoyance, following after her begrudgingly. She wanted to go home too, so finding something to appease Lonnie was more important.

They walked in silence, side by side, following twists and turns of the narrow ravine. Moving deeper into the valley.

“It wasn’t your fault.” Catra’s voice was soft, tentative as if wary her words were going to cause Adora to snap at her.

Instead Adora turned to her, confusion clear, with her furrowed brows and deep frown.

Catra groaned, “Louis’s death you idiot!”

“Oh…” Adora’s response was soft, barely a whisper.

“Granted, your plan sucked, but that's normal.” Catra shrugged, her backhanded remark earning her a small, paper thin smile from Adora. The blonde conceding amiably to her teasing as always.

“You ran off, half cocked and left us all to fend for ourselves.” Adora pointed out.

“Things went to shit and we were all improvising. K. I wanted to win, I just wasn’t stupid enough to depend on team work” to save the day!” Catra flung back sarcastically, flexing her fingers in air quotes.

“Fair, you always sucked at teamwork, but that’s normal.” Adora volleyed in return. Smirking, as she throws a jab back at Catra.

Catra smirked, bitterly. “ Anyway’s…I know you blame yourself, for what happened to Louis, cause you always do.”

“Well, I’m Squad leader…we lost the last trial and someone died under my command…I have to be accountable.” Adora admitted, her voice weak and fragile. As she stared forlorn down at her shuffling feet.

Catra scrubbed her hand down her face in frustration. Adora’s tendency to put the fault all on herself could be so annoying. She could barely remember their dual confessions back in her last den in the scrapyard. Too much alcohol, muddling the memories. Yet

the sick feeling swirling in her gut, as she took in Adora's cowering posture. Of her hugging herself for protection and shuffling in utter despair next to her it was unmistakable. The blondes defeated posture reeked of her having endured Shadow Weaver's special brand of 'motivation', same as her. Catra growled and shook her head violently to clear her head. She did not want to dwell on any of that bullshit.

"The last trail was forfeited and you didn't kill Louis!" She snarled towards the sky. "Green Squad did and they were all punished for tampering with equipment. "

"I know…" Adora sniffled, rubbing a finger under her nose. Tamping down the lump in her throat and the ache in her chest. Refusing to cry.

"Look, we're all kinda messed up about it. Reason why, we are all out in the god forsaken, ass crack of Etheria! Trying to build some kind of lame monument to make everyone feel better…we all suck!" Catra admitted, laughing ruefully as she punched Adora in the arm. In a valiant attempt to cheer her up.

"Let's go dumbass, I want to go home." Catra encouraged, having successfully derailed Adora's attempt to get her to open up about her own feelings once again. Over the years, she had turned their banter into verbal smoke and mirrors to distract Adora from the reality that their friendship was crumbling. Redirecting Adora's attention away from her towards something she would find more important. The blonde dummy needed to fix things, so it was easy to redirect her efforts away from the problems in their relationship. Needing to keep Adora at arms length, so she never picked up on her outright lies or half truths. Her subtle manipulation of Adora had become so refined it was basically an art form, now. Because being that open and vulnerable, to admit exactly what she thought of Adora. How deeply and repeatedly she had hurt her over the years, that was just too much to bear. Honestly…admitting her true feelings, it scared the crap out of her. So she refused to accept how much she truly resented her, hid her heartbreak behind this abrasive, uncaring attitude towards

everyone and the world. Changing the direction of their conversations, with snarky comebacks and her sharp wit. To have her believe everything was fine between them. That was normal, that was safe, that was something she could control.

As always, Adora took the bait and they eased into their typical easy banter. Taunting and teasing one another over trivial, stupid things. As they wandered across the valley. Sharing a canteen of water between them, sipping sparingly as the heat baked the earth and them as well.

The canyon walls fell away into the horizon as they walked deeper into the valley. Soon surrounded by rolling hills that obscured what lay behind.

"Are you doing ok? " Catra giggled over her shoulder, her mouth never fully closing anymore as she was panting heavily.

"I'm doing just fine, why?" Adora answered in an irritated and slightly breathless voice. She had gone quiet for a while now. Needing to focus on her footsteps, too stubborn to admit the heat was getting to her. Her whole body was drenched in sweat, she felt clammy and overheated. Her hair poof had long since deflated to a soggy mess, laying flat across her forehead.

Catra merely shrugged, "Just checking, sheesh, you don't need to bite my head…Off!" She yelped and then cried out in fear, as her feet suddenly slipped beneath her. As the ground caved in, the loose soil rolled down a steep slope and gained speed.

"CATRA!" Adora shouted, lurching into a frantic sprint to clear the distance between them. Refusing to give into the sudden light headed, dizzy nausea that swam her vision. As her heart rate sped up, knowing for certain now that she had a heat stroke.

Catra scrambled to regain her footing, toe claws extended and digging fruitlessly into the loosened earth. As she tumbled out of control down a steep hill, her pack flew off, landing out of view in

a cluster of dried bramble. As her hands scrambled to find purchase…grabbing onto nothing by more loose clay that slipped through her fingers. Leaving her swearing and screeching in horror as a muddy river came into view. She was headed right for it…with no way to stop herself. Squeezing her eyes shut, she rolled head over heels into the water with a loud splash. Not knowing how deep it was going to be, she braced for her head to go under.

Just as Adora reached the edge of the cliff, leaning over the broken earth. Valiantly trying to hold back her laughter and failing miserably. As she thinned her lips, snorting and coughing. Finding Catra sprawled on her back in knee deep water at the bottom. Staring up at the clear blue sky, with the most sour, unimpressed look on her face.

"You, doing alright?" Adora called down with laughing concern.

"Do I look like I am doing alright!" Catra shot back furiously.

Adora couldn't help herself, she dropped her pack to the ground and started laughing uproariously. Leaning over her knees, as she struggled to breath after a few minutes. Wiping away the stray tears, she slowly stood back up. Taking a quick survey of the winding river, finding that the further out it went from the muddy banks. The clearer the water became, as the river deepened. Becoming a sparkling ribbon of pure water cutting gracefully through the bottom of the canyon. Long dried grass curtained the embankment, dotted with clusters of waving cattails, some just brittle headless stalks along the sloping banks. Algae clung around large flat stones, embedded into the shoreline. Holding the river back from flooding the rest of the valley. The corpses of dead saplings huddled along the bends of the river. She didn't know if it was drought or the chemical toxin's the fortress pumped out into the Wailing River that had killed them. But the fact that the river was still clear in the center gave her hope for their survival. With a nod, she carefully climbed down the cliff towards the muddy river.

It took several minutes for Adora to safely navigate down the slippery slope of loose earth. Clumps of red clay, dislodged under her boots as she descended. Tumbling down around Catra's bare feet, splashing the limp, unresponsive magicat. Who refused to move out of the way. Merely squinting and flinching, as the water splashed her.

"Here let me help you up." Adora had waded ankle deep into the river and was now leaning over her, offering her a hand.

Catra grunted, reaching up with her own hand. Adora saw the mischievous gleam in her mismatched eye too late. As soon as Catra clutched her hand, she yanked her forward with all her strength.

"Naw, let me help you in!" She cackled in delight, as Adora yelped. Losing her balance and landing face first into the river.

Adora rolled over, sputtering and fuming.

"You are the worst!" She declared.

"Yeah…never shoulda trusted me." Catra responded in a languid sigh.

"The water's cold…it feels nice…" Adora moaned, as she lay sprawled beside Catra staring up at the clear sky above.

"Yeah….." Catra muttered, closing her eyes as she relaxed for the first time in days.

Dusk was falling over the valley, the last glowing embers of the Day Moon was burning upon the dark silhouette of the valley's walls far off in this distance. The scent of the campfire was exciting and filled Adora with a sense of comfort. They had retrieved their strike team and had spent the hot hours swimming in the river. Rogelio and Lonnie had scouted further south along

the banks as evening set in, gathering enough dried grasses, twigs from shrubs, even harvesting branches from the tiny saplings and reeds from the cattails on their back to camp. To build a fire at least for a little while.

Now Adora was sitting upon the banks, watching Catra who was still wading in waist deep water several yards out from shore. Partially hidden among the reeds and cattails. Her attention was completely fixed on the ripples and bubbles she saw beneath the surface. Her feline pupils blown wide and tracking shadows hiding within the river weeds. As her prey flitted between the submerged rocks.

Adora couldn't help herself, she had become completely mesmerized by Catra this evening. The feline had transformed out here in the wilds. No longer under the harsh scrutiny of Shadow Weaver. She was truly free to be herself, allowing the more feral, wild nature of her soul to hold dominance once more. She was hunting something, just like she had a child. Until Shadow Weaver had beaten those instincts into submission. Shaming her and forcing her to hide who she truly was.

Adora had a leg raised, leaning a bent arm on her knee as she smiled with pride at her best friend. Her soft blue eyes filled with wonder and awe, as Catra moved along the river. Every movement of her body was slow and precise, not wanting to give away her position to her prey. Then she struck like lightning, diving gracefully beneath the surface. Pouncing upon her target and pinning it to the river bed and then jumping clear of the water with a huge fish clutched in her claws above her head.

"I got it!" She shouted in triumph. "Did you see that Adora! I caught it…this…thing…" Her eyes were sparkling with victory. As she waded out of the water and tossed the scaly creature on the ground beside the blonde. Adora chuckled warmly at how delighted Catra was. As the feline stood, dripping before her watching the creature's fins flop on the ground until it was still.

“It smells good…I think we can eat this.” Catra squatted down and retrieved her prey in her hands. Bringing it up to her face and sniffing it.

Adora scrunched up her nose at the pungent smell of the creature. Quickly rising to her feet. As Catra took her index claw and sliced it down it’s belly, disemboweling it right then and there. Intent on eating it raw.

“Whoa, whoa…slow down…” Adora warned, as Catra was about to bring the slimy, scaly beast up to her mouth and take a big bite.

Catra paused, mid chomp looking up at Adora impatiently.

“Whatever that is, it’s huge. It could feed us all, how about we take it back to camp?” Adora offered, chucking a thumb over her shoulder.

“Fine.” Catra rolled her eyes with a begrudging grunt, but darted off towards the campfire with her prize.

As soon as Lonnie saw the creature she had taken charge. Explaining to them that it was a fish and she remembered how to prepare it. She had taken the fish from Catra and laid it out on a flat rock near the fire. Taking out her boot knife she finished cleaning the carcass and soon had the scales removed, deboned the meat and the filets cooking over the fire. Skewered to long branches that were once intended to be kindling.

Sitting around the fire, the team had settled into the warmth. The fire flickering gently across all their faces. Eating their meal, with soft conversation and joyful camaraderie passing easily between them.

“This is the best thing I have ever put into my mouth….” Kyle moaned, as he nibbled on his portion of fish.

“I know right…I could eat this everyday!” Adora agreed enthusiastically as she chewed. Elbowing Catra in the arm, who was sitting next to her.

The magicat responded by chuckling happily and refusing to make lewd remarks at Kyle's oblivious choice of words. She didn't have to be a total ass all the time.

“Thank you, Catra…this is amazing.” Lonnie tossed her gratitude between bites, from the other side of the fire. Kyle merely moaned in delight and nodded, as he worked on his own meal. Rogelio grunted in agreement from beside him, using his claws to rip his filet apart and toss flaky pieces into his salivating maw.

While Catra sat, head held high, preening at everyone's praise. She had never felt so valued by others, as she did then. The warmth of recognition settling in her chest, that her efforts today were appreciated. Filled her with self worth…a feeling she hadn’t felt in a long, long time. Her grin was huge, her fangs gleaming in the firelight. With the most open and honest smile. As her mismatched eyes shone with overwhelming pride.

Adora loved seeing her so at ease. It had been a long, long time since she had witnessed her best friend truly happy.

Catra had left her sleeping bag and crawled into Adora’s in the middle of the night, long after the fire had burnt out. Curling up beneath the blonde's bent knees, quickly warming the space with her added body heat. Her low, comforting purr serenaded them all as the night drew onward. It was a soft, comforting sound none of them had heard since their childhood. Adora had barely woken up, when she had felt Catra invade. A slow, euphoric smile pulled upon the blondes lips when she heard the magicat’s purr. The soft rumble had become so rare over the years, she knew this moment was precious.

Part Two

Chapter Notes

> Thank you LunaTheBlackWolf for your comment. Hope you had fish this week. I also hope this summer is not so hot!
> Moonlitvortex- I am working on filling in the gaps of what happened before my main fic. "Tapestry of Time." A way to freshen up my muse, before diving into the next arc.
> PinkStorm- I wanted to show how oblivious Adora was growing up, about her feelings for Catra.
> Thankyou all who have left Kudo's as well.
> Comments and kudo's are always appreciated.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day Four

They had refilled their canteen's and added purification tablets before leaving camp. The further they traveled away from the fortress the less barren it became. The natural world was still struggling to survive, but its resilience to find a way to live. Was truly awe inspiring.

There had been many clusters of young trees along the banks of the river to stop beneath and rest. Now it was well past mid day again, as they trekked up the side of the valley and back into the flat, dried out plains. The landscape beyond the valley was covered in scrub grass, the golden sea of hardy vegetation. Waving back and forth under the sudden bursts of cold wind. Small groves of dogwood and alder trees huddled along their route, their leaves sparse and shriveled. Illustrating that even this far out the pollution from the Fright Zone was still very apparent within the soil.

Everyone was refreshed and in much better spirits. Adora was once more in the lead with Catra on her right. Lonnie walked a

few paces behind, her map in her hands. Glancing up briefly from time to time from the wrinkled, worn out piece of paper attempting to find any kind of markers that could be recognized. Sliding her dark hazel eyes to the metal compass in her left hand that at least told her they were heading in the right direction at least. So that was something she could rely on. While Rogelio and Kyle took up the rear at a much slower pace. The blonde was limping now, not leaning on the crutch as much. Which was also a good sign.

Conversation as always was infrequent, as they each spent the day lost in their own thoughts. Basking in the nature surrounding them, listening to the soft calls of birds hidden in the underbrush. The rustle of the small animal's scavenging among the mossy rocks and tall grasses. It was peaceful and allowed each of them to just breathe and lazily take in the beauty of the wild's, long denied them within the suffocating confines of the fortress.

By nightfall, they were camped out in the open under the dark sky, filled with shimmering ribbons of light that were dancing over them. The vividly glowing moon's, of all sizes and hues accenting the glorious colors of the sky above their heads.

"You don't see that in the Fright Zone." Lonnie commented in a hush, laying on top of her sleeping bag with her arms crossed behind her head. Gazing up in wonder at the mysterious beauty sprawling above.

"It's really something…kinda pretty." Kyle answered, in soft breath. Sitting by the campfire with a blanket draped over his shoulders. Staring out to the dark horizon, blue eyes wide as he watched the light's twinkle and dance.

"Tama told us a story about it…once." Adora responded, her voice tender and filled with reverence. She was laying out on the bare ground in the dark, just beyond the firelight. Catra was sitting beside her, leaning back on her elbows. Her claws kneading into the grass. "She told us that the lights in the sky are the souls of the dead." The feline continued Adora's remembrance, with a

somber sigh. Gazing up at the sky, with wide unblinking eyes and licking her lips nervously. As an eerie, melancholy surrounded them.

Everyone was silent for a long time after her comment.

"Maybe…they know what we're doing and are watching out for us…" Lonnie offered, as she turned and smiled fondly towards Rogelio. Who was sitting next to Kyle, poking the fire with a stick. The lizard had been brooding into the flames for most of the evening. He never even lifted his head to acknowledge her, blinking rapidly as if he had gotten soot in his eyes.

Adora turned and offered Lonnie a bright, hopeful smile. While Catra took a deep breath, rubbing her wrist across her moist eyes to make sure the tears would not be noticed.

"I miss them…" Kyle moaned then sniffled miserably.

"Duh, We all do." Catra growled, picking up a stone from the ground and throwing it into the darkness beside her.

Adora nibbled on her bottom lip, as she sat up, tentatively reaching for Catra's hand. Who promptly snarled and stood up out of her reach and disappeared into the night. She was upset and needed time to compose herself, unwilling to show weakness.

Adora sighed, raising her knees up and crossing her arms over them. Ducking her head out of view to conceal her own tears, as she felt them falling down her cheeks.

Lonnie took a deep breath, averting her eyes back towards the sky. Seeing Adora cry made her really uncomfortable. Kyle merely nodded, pulling the blanket over his head to hide. While Rogelio started to poke the fire more violently.

Day Five

Adora had them up and started out well before the Day Moon rose. With the gray pre dawn light hovering around them. They marched in single file, down the open prairie towards the looming silhouette of Scorpion Hills. The air was moist, with a low fog wrapping around their feet. A somber morning, accompanying the troop as if conjured by their grief. Slowly, moving steadily into the now rolling hills of dried, yellow grass as the temperature began to rise. As the Day Moon greeted them in the distance, illuminating the rocky landscape on the horizon. As its light cast the blanket of clouds into a glorious fiery glow . By midday the air was scorching, but the low roar of the sea was echoing like static far in the distance. Catra kept raising her chin and sniffing the air, curious about the salty scent in the air. The sound spurns Adora to keep them moving, with no breaks. So they ate while marching. As they slowly mounted steeper hills, heading upward down narrow footpaths into the high reaches of the sprawling canyon. Scaling sheer rock faces to barren heaths, cautiously trekking along rocky crags that guarded this treacherous shoreline. The cliffs loomed high over the wide heaths that they walked across. Soon replaced by the rocky shores of the southernmost bend of the Serpentine Straits, falling far below them. As evening set in, the watery horizon stretching before them was painted in vivid hues of pink and purples. Catching their attention and holding firm, as they traveled ever upward to the very peak of the canyon. The daunting cliffs that overlooked the rough waters below were as breathtaking, as they were terrifying. The shoreline was scattered with tall protruding rock formations jutting out of the surf like sharp teeth. The sheer violence of the waves that smashed against them, sent shivers of dread through each one of them. The sea foam frothing and submerging some of the shorter rocks, only illustrated how deadly this part of the Straight could be. The wind gusted from time to time, kicking dirt up into their eyes as it howled by. The squad was silent. Moving in formation as always, staring in awe at the wondrous, yet threatening landscape that now surrounded them. The air was crisp, the tang of salt pricking their tongues and drying out their eyes. Catra kept her ears pinned, the roar of the water and the howling of the wind made her insanely nervous. How Lonnie saw this place as

beautiful was beyond her…but the girl was never right in the head.

“Are we here now?” Catra threw an irritated arm outward towards the tall grassy plateau. That stretched outward from the sharply sloping hillside they had just traversed. She was dead tired, annoyed by the constant white noise of the sea and just wanted to get this all over with so she could go home!

“Close enough I guess.” Lonnie stated, she was hot and completely exhausted. Dumping her pack onto the ground and collapsing with it.

“Ok, let's rest a bit then we can divide up into teams to look around for something to build the monument. “ Adora commanded, remaining standing as her squad all deflated to the ground. Oblivious to their exhaustion and the fast approaching dusk. As the Day Moon was now completely set, leaving only a faint glowing hue upon the watery horizon. Already a few of the smaller Moon’s could be seen glowing softly in the black backdrop of the sky.

“Do you not have an off switch…oh, fearless leader.” Catra complained, rolling her eyes in aggravation. “Sit down and relax… with the rest of us, sheesh.”

Adora grimaced in regret, she was right. She had been pushing them all rather hard today. Humbled, by Catra’s snark as always. She sat down with a huff, pulling off her pack and fanning her sweaty face with a hand.

“Fine…” Adora grumbled, “Let’s set up camp here for the night. We can survey the area in the morning.”

“Finally…” Catra smirked and poked her between the eyes with a claw, when she conceded. Adora raised her eyebrows, in annoyance. How insubordinate was her second in command going to get? She gave in, Catra’s didn’t need to rub her little win in her face. Slightly humiliated and in need to assert herself, as the one

in command. She offered Catra a teasing grin. Then Adora lunged, determined to put Catra in her place. The magicat had left the soft part under her raised arm wide open. So the blonde was quick to infiltrate it with her fingers. Digging them into Catra's armpit, mercilessly. Catra squealed and recoiled, curling up on the ground as Adora straddled her. Tickling her all over, as she writhed and screamed. Adora would admit, she enjoyed pinning Catra down and dominating her. She had no ill intentions, at least not consciously.

Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio were all laughing at Catra's expense. The disrespect had the magicat's blood boiling. Catra gnashed her teeth, struggling to temper her fury. Refusing to lash out and scratch Adora, as she once did as a child. She never wanted to hurt her again, but sometimes it was really hard to restrain herself. When Adora obviously was trying to dominate her and humiliate her in front of the other's.

"Get off…" Catra growled, bucking Adora off violently. Then leaping to her feet and storming off to the edge of the cliff. Where she sat down once more, facing away from them all. Scowling, down at the rocky beach below. Her tail curled around her ankles as her ears lowered sadly. Sometimes, Adora was just such an ass!

"Catra…come on…I was just fooling around." Adora tried to explain as she slowly stood up. Staring forlorn and repentant towards the now brooding magicat perched at the edge of the plateau. Catra never even twitched an ear, completely ignoring her.

"Oh, leave her to sulk, Adora." Lonnie waved her to sit back down, starting to put away her map and rummage for some more ration bars.

Adora gazed at Catra for a long time, her once gleeful expression falling into a worried frown. With a huff, Adora tightened her ponytail and walked off to have some alone time of her own.

Heading away in the opposite direction, towards the jagged ledges of an overhanging cliff on the far side of the plateau.

Lonnie groaned, tossing Kyle and Rogelio each a bar. "I am getting so sick of those two and their hot and cold routine."

Rogelio began to growl and hiss, waving his scaly arms towards Catra and Adora. Explaining the situation as he saw it, to his two best friends.

'They grew up together, just like us in a bleak, loveless environment. In which the only care and support they could depend on was with each other. But Shadow Weaver has weaponized that bond. She has been pitting them against each other for years in some twisted competition for her approval. It was inevitable that their friendship turned to rivalry. Adora has always been that wretched crones favorite, while Catra could never measure up.

It is only natural that they would grow to resent each other. Shadow Weaver has chipped away at Catra's self worth her entire life. While constantly building up Adora, telling her she is destined for greatness, that she will lead the Horde to victory. Catra acts out because she is hurting. Her achievements were constantly overlooked and she blames Adora for it. All she wants is for Adora to show her that she matters. While Adora just wants her to be honest and forthright with her. Tell her what she needs, what she wants to be happy…and Adora would give everything she was, everything she had to make that happen. But Adora gets frustrated with her, because she is so volatile. Emotional awareness is not Adora's strength, other people's feelings are too complicated for her to figure out. So she blames herself and obsesses over the little things she might have done wrong to piss Catra off. Always seeking ways to fix things…to fix them. But none of that matters, they need to sit down and just talk it all out. Realize that they both still love each other and need to be a team again. In that way they would both win. ' Rogelio finished his rant, heaving a deep sigh of utter exasperation.

While Kyle nodded as if he totally understood whatever the lizard had said. Lonnie just sat there with a perplexed expression.

"We seriously need to figure out how to communicate with you, this is getting absurd." She mumbled and shook her head.

Day Six

Catra awoke in the darkness, shaking off the fragments of a very strange dream. Her unconscious mind, no doubt twisted by the harsh sounds of cannon fire. That now echoed just beyond their campsite. She knew instinctively that Adora was already awake and gone somewhere. Her scent lingered nearby.

Rolling out of her sleeping bag, she quickly scanned the campsite. Their fire had burned down to ash and embers, Etheria's many moons were high. Glowing in faint repose behind the heavy clouds that had encroached while the strike team slept. But, lack of light never affected her ability to see. So Catra remained crouched, alert and wary beside her sleeping bag. Ears pinned back as concussion blasts erupted like thunder out upon the Straight. She quickly scanned the plateau beyond. As Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio began to rouse from their slumber. She noticed Adora's silhouette, hidden slightly behind a boulder near the edge of the cliff. Staring out towards the water below, her boot knife clutched tight in her right hand. Every muscle was tensed, coiled to strike and repel any threat. Her military training took over, almost unconsciously.

Catra slunk silently towards her, ear's twitching and tail hung low. The very tip twitched as she moved at a slow, cautious pace. Not wanting to draw any attention to herself. As she crept up beside the ever vigilant blonde, who had no doubt been keeping watch instead of sleeping. Always on guard, always protecting her team. Catra would berate her later. If she was their leader then she could have delegated some of the responsibilities, like setting up a watch rotation. Instead of staying up all night and exhausting herself instead. But whatever, Adora was a self sacrificing idiot… let her deal with the consequences.

“What's going on?’ Catra hissed, near the blondes ear.

“There’s a vessel under attack by a Horde patrol ship.” Adora answered, crisply.

Catra leaned around her, taking in the battle. Her eyes narrowed, as her once curious expression. Swiftly twisted to one of obvious disgust. The merchant cutter being attacked was clearly inferior in every way. It had no weapon’s, sleek and small. Made of wood with simple foil sails. While the Horde battle ship was a high tech behemoth, of metal and thrusters, with laser cannons mounted in a huge turret. Set atop the foredeck. That was effortlessly shredding the sails and reducing the hull to splinter’s. It took less than a minute for the smaller ship to go down in flames, disappearing beneath the dark waves.

“Well, what the hell was that about?” Catra exclaimed furiously.

“I don’t know, but I am sure the Naval officer’s had a good reason to destroy it.” Adora shrugged.

Lonnie had reached their side by that time, she stood fearlessly out in the open at the edge of the cliff. Arms crossed over her chest, scowling at the Horde ship. She never said a word, just grunted with distaste and returned to the campsite. While Adora and Catra watched the Warship circle, the debris field of the wreckage for several minutes. Fishing out any survivors.

Rogelio was quick to restart the campfire, once the Horde ship had disappeared from sight. Sailing back up the Straight and disappearing along the rocky bend of the shoreline, as the naval base was further north. They were once more huddled around the fire, with blankets over their shoulders attempting to warm up. Or perhaps hide away their shame and frustrations at being a part of the same army. That had just preyed upon a weaker, unarmed and no doubt civilian vessel.

“That wasn’t a fair fight…that was a slaughter.” Lonnie growled, as she dug the toes of her boots into the soft soil. Finally unable to

keep her opinion contained.

“I'm sure those sailor’s were insurgence, or…or smuggler’s aiding the Princess’s. The crew must have had intel on the ship before destroying it.” Adora defended.

“Sure…” Catra drawled sarcastically, rolling her eyes. “Unarmed civilians…in a wooden boat are a threat.”

“The Horde are not the bad guys!” Adora snapped back, Catra’s attitude was starting to try her patience.

Catra merely huffed, adjusting her position beside her. To give Adora the cold shoulder, as she now faced away from her. Once more seething with silent fury, as Adora once again refused to accept how evil the Horde was. Choosing to believe the lies they were always fed instead of what she had just witnessed with her own eyes!

Adora ignored the slight, holding her blanket around herself tighter and focusing on the fire. Valiantly, attempting to make peace with the injustice she had just witnessed. They had no real facts, beyond what they had witnessed. She refused to just blindly accuse the Horde of murder, that was treason…

“Do you ever think about just defecting?’ Kyle offered, in a timid voice.

“Levi and Max were going to do just that.” Lonnie shrugged.

“Yeah, I know. That’s why they fixed that skiff?” Adora grumbled, grinding the sharp point of a stick into the soft ground between her raised knees.

“Surprised you managed to figure that out.” Catra snapped back, bitterly. Masking her disdain towards Adora with a teasing smirk.

Adora once again ignored her mean comment, that she was stupid.

“Honestly, Where would you go…into the Crimson Waste to die? Get lost in the Whispering Woods and die! Or just give yourself up to the first Princess you saw ? They would kill you on sight. “ Adora shot back, towards Kyle. Her tone was more venomous than she had intended. The blonde boy flinched and cowered lightly into his blanket under her heated glare.

“I don’t know…” Kyle whimpered.

“It doesn’t matter, we can’t just fuck off, the other’s are covering for us. So we have to go back.” Lonnie reminded them all.

“I can’t believe you guys would even think about disserting?” Adora was aghast, shaking her head in disappointment. “The Horde took us all in as kids, took care of us, trained us to fight. Gave us all a purpose. We have a duty to Etheria to defeat the Princess and their dangerous magic. Bring order and prosperity to the planet.”

“Whatever.” Catra snorted in distaste, “We don’t owe the Horde anything, we had to earn our food and shelter. They offered us nothing without an ulterior motive. We’re nothing but meat for Hordak’s War Machine. All that propaganda has rotted your brain. Seriously, Adora there ain’t anything noble about War. We’re just cog’s in the machine…” She snorted, flopping onto her back and crossing her arms behind her head to watch the sky slowly warm with the coming of dawn.

“So you’d leave?” Adora was appalled.

“In a heartbeat!” Catra professed. “If I had somewhere better to go” She shrugged, completely noncommittal about the whole thing.

Adora just stared at her, with an open mouthed dumbfounded expression.

As the brilliant rays of dawn illuminated the blanket of clouds overhead. Casting them in a vivid orange glow as if the sky had been set on fire. They split up into two groups to scour the far

reaching shoreline. For something grand enough to carve an epitaph. Lonnie and the boys headed into the jagged sandstone shelter's of rocks that lined the base of the cliffs along the northern shore. While Adora and Catra went south, where the beach was more open. Where the ridge of the low lying cliffs, covered in tall grass, sloped more gently into the shore. This part of the beach was covered in small pebbles, smoothed and shiny from ebb and flow of the surf. Flat limestone slabs, created natural stairways to nowhere. Butting against the base of the cliffs. All poked by the salt deposits of the sea and stained with lichen. As the cliff had eroded back from the edge of the water over the last thousand years.

It didn't take long for Adora to start poking the feline about her disloyalty to the Horde.

"So, in this hypothetical desertion.." She hedged, as they walked down the beach. Her boots crunching against the tiny stones. "Where would you go, what would you do?"

Catra merely arched an eyebrow, acknowledging her as she walked beside her. Throwing a shiny, flat stone into the foam, as the waves crept near her bare feet.

"You never thought about taking off and never going back?" Catra turned the comment back on her. "Even when things got shitty, when your stomach hurt because you lost your food privileges for a couple days for not meeting Shadow Weaver's expectations? Or when you flunked an exam in junior training and dreaded going back to the barracks that night. Cause you knew that either Lazlo would punish you…or Shadow Weaver would be waiting for you for "[personal tutoring".. Or how about the time you got thrown in the box for a week, for excessive retaliation against the blue squad? After they trashed our bunkroom for the billionth time last season. Or the humiliation of our entire squad being locked up in the stocks for a week, after Lazlo caught us with stolen ration bars and bottles of contraband a couple years back. When we tried celebrating surviving another yearly trial."

Adora was quick to interrupt, as Catra could go on and on about all the harsh punishment they had received growing up.

“One, I failed Shadow Weaver’s expectations as a kid because you did not stop fooling around while I tried to study. Always distracting me, with honestly better things to do.” Adora smirked, knocking her shoulder against her’s.

“Racing to the Forge was so much fun!” Catra grinned. “I kicked your ass all the time.”

“Because you cheat!” Adora huffed, her sharp glare was cutting but brief. .

“Don’t blame me, you're the slowest person on the planet.” Catra countered, poking her claw between Adora’s eyes. Her taunting, instantly softening the blonde's indignation to a fond smirk.

“Anyway…yeah...I’ve thought about leaving too. I just would never actually go through with it.” Adora shrugged, “I mean what’s really out there for us? We have a plan…and I like our plan.”

“I know, I know.” Catra whipped a stone out across the water. “We are going to rise up the ranks and take over the leadership of the Horde and change how it does things.”

“That’s the plan.” Adora nodded, offering her a soft reassurance. As she picked up a stone, she skipped it across the water.

Catra watched ruefully, as Adora’s stone bounced further than her own. Rolling her eyes, in mock annoyance. Everything was a competition between them, unconsciously or not. It was how they were raised…

Together…right.” Adora smiled fondly down at her, reaching out and clasping her hand lightly in solidarity. As they stood side by side, watching the waves crash against the rocks along the shore.

Instantly a small purr, rumbled from Catra’s chest. As they continued to walk down the beach hand in hand. The Day Moon slowly rose higher into the clear blue sky, as morning took hold. It had been a very long time, since she felt her and Adora were a team. She refused to allow any of her bitterness to taint this moment, she wanted to believe in this fantasy. That nothing would ever come between them…

Chapter End Notes

I decided to write one more chapter just to wrap it all up.

Part Three

Chapter Notes

> Thank you PinkStorm and LunaTheBlackWolf for your comments and all those who left kudo's.

They had found nothing, but a long stretch of empty beach on their journey south. With the odd boulder here and there, half submerged in the surf. Its surface, smoothed and polished from the tides, just like the tiny pebbles that scattered amongst the pale sand. The light was dimming on the watery horizon, when they finally gave up and turned around. The thin layer of clouds that blanketed the sky all day. Had left them both in a somber, melancholy mood. Now those very same clouds that were hovering across the water and over the worn cliffs of Scorpion Hills. Alighted in glorious color. The rolling hills of atmosphere were a contrast of vivid glowing hues and twilight shadows. Catching both Catra and Adora's gaze more than once as they slowly meandered back up to the campsite upon the plateau.

The endless expanse of open sky above was rather daunting to take in. The beauty out here beyond the industrial confines of the Fright Zone, was unmatched, to anything they had witnessed before. Leaving them breathless at the majesty of the natural world. They had experienced only a fraction of its beauty, when they were sophomores during their survival training. Their drill sergeant only led them a few miles outside of the Fright Zone. Enough to get an idea of how wondrous and deadly the wilderness could be. How difficult it would be to survive without the aid of the Fortress's resources. Leaving them out in the wasteland just long enough to yearn for the safety and security of the barracks.

But this time they had ventured far into Etheria's wilds. Finding to their surprise that it was possible to survive outside the Fright Zone. After all this talk of deserting the Horde, of taking off and not going back. Adora couldn't help but dwell upon the prospect

of just disappearing without a trace. How easy it would be to just pick a direction and commit to finding her own purpose, build a life of her own…out here. She finally allowed her true desires to surge forth. Basking in this sense of true freedom, of being no longer tethered to duty or responsibility. To want…it was intoxicating for Adora…suddenly the need to run and keep running as fast and as far away from the Fright Zone crashed over her like a tidal wave. As quick as those fantasies manifested, a jolt of anxiety electrified her whole body. Followed by a great deal of guilt and self loathing for even contemplating it. Lost to her inner turmoil, as she stared up at the open sky above. Her pensive expression, twisting to that of raw terror. Suddenly she needed to feel anchored…blindly reaching out. She hastily clasped Catra's hand and held firm.

Catra squeezed back in acknowledgement. The action, drawing Adora's gaze back down from the open sky. Falling upon the most important person in her life, her misty blue eyes locking with Catra's and holding on tight.

"Get out of your head, Dummy." Catra rapped her knuckles on Adora's forehead. A cocky smirk on her lips, while the worry in her eyes betrayed her attempt to seem unconcerned.

Adora sighed and smiled gratefully down at her best friend. They may get into fights, argue venomously, get frustrated and angry at one another, but they always manage to find their way back to each other, that would never change. It gave her hope, that no matter how hard the road ahead was going to get, how bleak her life seemed. She had Catra, the one constant, never changing aspect of her existence that she could always rely on. Her care and support, it meant everything.

Tired and sore, they trudged up the last of the worn footpath to the plateau. That their campsite was nestled upon. In the time it took to trudge all the way up there, the Day Moon had set and a gloomy dusk had settled in. Finding the rest, hard at work. Stacking heavy rocks to form a sturdy base, around what looked

like a whole ass dead tree! To keep that petrified monstrosity upright.

“Well…that definitely is something?” Catra braced her hands on her hips, cocking her chin towards the tree in a flippant manner. Blinking in complete amazement that those three manage to haul that huge, piece of driftwood up the cliff.

“Took you guys long enough to get back.” Lonnie retorted, as she stood up after adjusting a stone within the base. Taking several steps back to survey the boy's final efforts. As Rogelio and Kyle adjusted the massive log making sure it was secure.

“It looks great!” Adora grinned, pulling out her boot knife and eager to start carving.

“Let's get a fire started first, so you can see, idiot. Otherwise your going to cut yourself.” Catra lightly shoved Adora aside, making the blonde stumble away from the log before she could stab the wood with her knife.

“Alright, fine.” Adora conceded, flipping her blade with a cocky flourish and shoving it back into her boot.

“We only got two knives, Adora’s and Rogelio’s so we are going to have to take turns anyway.” Kyle shrugged, “You might as well start, Cat. You don’t need light to see.”

“Point made.” Catra nodded, turning to Adora and holding out her hand. A smug smile pulled on her lips, as her eyes began to shine in the dark.

Adora grunted and pulled out her knife, handing it to Catra. She couldn’t help but stare in wonder at her best friend. That nocturnal glow that engulfed Catra’s eyes, was uncanny, yet so very, strikingly beautiful to Adora.

Catra never noticed Adora admiring her, already prowling towards the tree. She walked around the trunk a couple times looking for

the perfect place to carve her epitaph to Tama. While the other's restarted the fire.

Soon the fire was blazing, casting the weathered gray bark in a brilliant flickering light. The smoothed surface seemed to shine as if it was truly made of stone.

Adora wandered around to where Catra had been carving, diligently for the last half an hour. Finding the feline had drawn three faces, similar to the etching that they had carved into Adora's metal bunk post. One was Catra, younger, with wild hair and no mask. The middle was Tama, with two fluffy ears and a curly mane and on the right was Adora sporting her telltale hair poof and ponytail. Below the innocent smiling faces were three very prominent and honest words.

Best Friends Forever

Adora sniffled and rubbed the tip of her nose, the ache in her chest growing more painful as she fought not to cry.

"It's the truth, right…don't make a big deal about it!" Catra never turned around, ducking her head to shield her wet cheeks from Adora. She handed the blonde back her knife then she punched her in the shoulder and shuffled away into the darkness to deal with her grief…alone and away from prying eyes.

Adora sighed, then nodded. Moving around the tree to find her own place to carve. She wrote only a small quote, but it held so much meaning to her. About how she felt about not just Tama for all them…

Never forgotten

It took less than an hour, but soon the epitaph had five carvings and meaningful farewells, all to honor their friends. They all sat around the fire, studying their markers with a mixture of pride, longing and despair.

“Fuck…my chest hurts…” Lonnie groused, handing Kyle a ration bar. As she idly rubbed her fingertips between her breasts. Voicing her sorrow, in a subtle attempt to connect to the other’s who were all obviously hurting in their own ways.

“You must have over exerted yourself helping us haul that big tree…it was way heavier than we thought.” Kyle grimaced, declining the ration bar. His stomach was way too upset to eat. His observation was just a flimsy excuse, to hide Lonnie’s obvious heartache. A knee jerk reaction, to protect her from showing weakness.

“Yeah…probably.” Lonnie agrees, shoving the ration bars back into her pack. Silently, hiding away her tears as she took her time to tuck the bars away inside. Kyle's dismissal, to her subtly reaching out. Causing her to recoil from opening up about her feelings.

No one really felt like eating. The night drew on, in relative silence. Rogelio kept busy, feeding the fire. While Kyle huddled in his blanket staring up at the dark sky, his eyes searching amongst the huddled clouds for sliver’s of moonlight. His expression was pensive. Lost in his thoughts.

“Do you think there's an afterlife?” He finally verbalized what he had been thinking about so intently for the last hour.

“My people celebrate our ancestor’s once a year during the cool season…I don’t remember much…but it wasn’t a sad time. We would spend it with our families, eating good food, playing games, walking among the row’s of ancestral gravestones. That honored the dead and just talked about the ones that passed. Sharing stories about them and in a way they lived again…if briefly… I think by remembering them every year, they can’t really die… cause they sorta live on inside of each of us.” Lonnie offered, glancing over at their grave marker with a sad, lingering stare. Her wet hazel eyes took in every worn down crevice, every twisted branch and smoothed knot. As if she was seeking to memorize it all, so she could carry the memory back to the barracks.

“Ok…let’s all share one good story about each one of them.” Kyle grinned, eager to try and lighten the tragic atmosphere around the fire.

“Urgh…” Catra groaned, in distaste. Pulling her knees up tighter to her chest and tucking her tail tight around her ankles. Her chest ached, throbbing as if it was being punched over and over again. Her fur was fluffed out, and her skin felt oddly, hot and tingly. At the prospect of sharing stories about their lost bunkmates. It was an uncomfortable feeling, yet soothing at the same time.

Adora turned towards her, paying her a reproachful frown. Only picking up on her outwardly, poor attitude about Kyle’s idea. Not understanding how nervous and scared, sharing her thoughts and feelings would be for Catra. Who had spent her whole life, hiding her true self from a world that had no intention of ever understanding her.

“Fine…ok…I’ll start.” Catra conceded, pulling off her mask and setting it on the ground beside her. “Tama was a…” She took a deep breath before continuing. “ pain…She was a klutz always stepping on my tail when we marched single file down the corridors. That uncoordinated menace left me with a permanent kink, right near the tip.” Catra gently rubbed down the length of her tail with her hand. Focusing on the calming sensation of her stroking hand, instead of the heavy, sorrowful looks from the others. Taking a few moments to push down the lump in her throat and ease the tremor in her voice. “She always had her head in the clouds, got in as much trouble as I did. “ Catra laughed softly, a tender smile gracing her lips. “She was so fucking slow, so we always got extra laps every morning. I swear we never got breakfast as first year cadets, because of her. I blame her for ending up being so short. Cause I never got the nutrition I needed as a kid.” Catra smirked, attempting to lighten her discomfort at opening up, with unflattering remarks.

“Where exactly are you going with this?” Lonnie gripped with an eye roll. It seemed Catra was incapable of being real.

Catra was silent for a bit, building her courage to admit how she truly felt.

"I miss it…looking out for her…she needed me…and I…I needed her too. " Catra's wet gaze cut to Adora for just a second. The hope and yearning to one day hear those very same words mirrored back to her from Adora's own lips. The open vulnerability in her eyes was brief, but heavy with so many feelings.. all left unsaid.

Adora never noticed Catra's pain or her searching glance for comfort and reassurance. That she was wanted, that she was needed…that she mattered to Adora. Because Adora was too focused on her own grief. She was sitting ramrod straight, beside her. Hands twisting in her lap, staring down at her boots, at the end of her crossed legs. Her expression was forlorn and contemplative. Leaving Catra, who felt so scared at opening up. Alone and her needs once again unnoticed, by the one person she believed she could depend on.

"She had a goofy sense of humor." Lonnie added, "Always making weird faces, whenever you looked at her during meal time."

"Yeah, I laughed so hard once. I snorted water out my nose." Kyle grinned, his cheek warmed by the sweet memory.

"I miss her bedtime stories ....They always helped me sleep." Adora whispered, her eyes clouded as her gaze drew inward. Despair and longing, misting over the blue, turning them a dull watery gray.

Catra's ears suddenly fell low at Adora's honest yearning for Tama. Her mismatched eyes were now pooling with tears of rejection. She had been comforting Adora for years, waking up in the middle of the night to Adora sleep fighting. She would crawl into the blondes bunk, cuddle up to her and purr softly. To hear how little Adora found her efforts. It just thrust that dagger even more firmly into her heart, that once again she was not enough…she was never enough. Her chest ached even more now, Catra

pressed a fist between her breasts as she averted her pained gaze outward toward the edge of the plateau. Desperate to hide how deeply Adora had hurt her.

"Ami and Arron were always up to something…" Kyle chuckled, a small rueful smile creeping upon his lips. As he clutched the blanket more firmly under his chin.

"Never anything good." Lonnie added dryly, as Rogelio growled in agreement. Catra's brutal honesty regarding Tama, had set the tone.

Rogelio glanced backward at the symbol he had carved for the two twins. A sideways 8 that meant eternity. No one had been very close to the twins. They never attempted to make friends, depending only on each other.

A heavy silence hung around the fire for a long time.

"Ami was the evil mastermind of those two.." Catra added, once she had regained her composure. Turning back towards the fire and rolling her eyes in mock disdain. As she had been that girl's main target for years. But, it was hard to stay mad at someone who was dead. "Arron just did her bidding like a good little minion." Catra finished with a long drawn out sigh. Leaning back on her elbows, to recline against the hard packed earth. Digging her claws into clumps of grass, as she rolled onto her side, avoiding Adora as much as possible.

"They kinda picked on you, didn't they?" Adora asked, turning to regard her with a concerned frown. She was making light of what Ami and Arron did to her best friend and she knew it. As Catra had suffered both insults and injuries at the hands of those diabolical twins. Resulting in Adora having to take the badly wounded magicat to the infirmary for treatment many times.

Catra merely shrugged, not really agreeing or admitting to anything. Her relationship with Ami had always been a war of wills. Always seeking to dominate the other. During drills, combat

training, test scores.. Trying to beat the other in cadet ranking…if they were in proximity of each other for too long during their brief down time in the bunk room before bed. It was inevitable that they would be at each other's throats. They were rivals, fiercely competitive and brutally vindictive to each other. It got so bad. She honestly believed Ami had been trying to get rid of her at one point.

Kyle was looking at her, with a worried expression that bordered on pity. He was pranked by Adora and Catra, growing up but it was never as harmful as what Catra endured. Catra caught his eyes with hers and curled her lip upward, snarling pointedly in his direction.

Instantly, cowed. Kyle shifted his gaze to the fire instead.

"Bryson…" Lonnie scratched her nose, absently.

Kyle shrugged, "I never really got to know him. He hung out with Max and Levi most of the time."

Lonnie rose to her feet and headed over to their grave marker. "Those two sent me, with a note to write for Byrson." She gazed thoughtfully at the words she had carved.

Bravest of us all

"Yeah…he had a big heart." Kyle nodded, seeking to get everyone else to talk. Recalling how diligently the boy sought to care for Levi and Max. He was always there when those two needed him.

"And a big mouth!" Catra snapped back, but there was no heat in her tone. Kyle huffed in annoyance. As Catra was, as expected. Not playing along and saying nice things, but being her typical snarky self.

"Sure, he ate a-lot…." Adora nodded. Feigning ignorance of Catra's mean comment, as she shrugged. Attempting as always to ease the tension, Catra created with her bad attitude.

“He tried to burst my eardrums every time he played that stupid harmonica!” Catra shot back over her shoulder at Adora. Sitting up and rubbing her poor tender ears in memory of the sharp pain. That pierced like dagger’s threw her head, every time he squealed and squawked that torture device at the top of his lungs. Either, completely oblivious of her presence in the room or being callous and uncaring about what he was doing to her? Defending her harsh comment, by explaining why she said it. Not allowing Adora to change the narrative to something less insulting.

“ Levi said he was acting weird the day he died. All fired up and being far more reckless than ever. A few older, Indigo Sophomores were teasing them at the mess hall during supper. Calling them useless, meat shields that wouldn’t last a day on the front lines. Since, I guess their posted training scores that day were epically poor. Going to the Quarry had been his idea. They went out there with the Indigo Squad member’s to prove they were brave. The race up the pellet piles…he dared the Indigo’s first. He was trying to prove himself.” Lonnie commented, earnestly.

Catra curled in on herself, ear’s falling low as her tail tip flicked anxiously. The guilt once more weighed heavy upon her conscience. Her regret in the years since Bryson’s death had not lessened one but. The unbearable pressure upon her conscience was now suffocating. She felt absolutely sick, struggling to swallow the bile burning her throat. Revolted by what she had done, how horribly she had acted…that day. Unconsciously she reached for her battle mask, scrubbing a hand, through her long hair. Pulling back the wild, wavy mass of loose bangs, to affix the metal piece of armor back upon her brow. Scowling down at the ground, as her self loathing rose up to devour her once more.

“That’s not like Bryson…he was usually rather easy going…he was never really very competitive or confrontational.” Adora’s expression was grim, pensive. Trying to sort out why Bryson had acted so out of character that day?

“Weird right, what got into him that day?” Lonnie brushed her hand across the carved words.

Catra groaned, refusing to acknowledge once again that his death might just be all her fault. Pushing the blame onto the deceased boy. Her inner monologue was bitter and spiteful at how reckless and stupid he had been. On the heels of her attempt to absolver herself. Was her own true self reflection. It whispered how vile her actions had been. She had lost her temper, she had scared him in the locker room, made him feel like a coward and stolen his Harmonica. His most prized possession. Her bullying had pushed him to prove himself. He wouldn't have gotten it into his head that he needed to pull off some reckless stunt to prove he was worth something. If only she had only controlled her rage, walked away…

Adora glanced over at Catra, surveying how her friend was now once again hugging her knees tight. The firelight flickered across the bronze metal, glinting off the sharp edges of her mask. Her haunted eyes hidden beneath the heavy shadow's cast by the brow of the mask. Ears pinned low and tight to the back of her head. Adora was sitting close enough to still witness the deep sorrow now engulfing her. As her down cast eyes were shimmering with unshed tears. The magicat was looking so small hunched over her knees. Biting her lower lip hard, drawing blood as she valiantly holds back her sobs. Making soft, whimper and jagged hiccupping sounds. Adora shoulders are not quite brushing up against Catra's. But able to discreetly walk her hand behind the magicat and rub her curved back in small, soothing circles. Offering what she could for comfort, without the others noticing. Catra flinched at the sudden soft touch, blinking rapidly to clear her tears as she ducked her head behind her crossed arms. Not allowing Adora or the other's to see how upset she was. She didn't deserve this comfort…but also didn't shy away from it either.

Adora was confused, she never thought Catra and Bryson had much to do with one another. Catra didn't like him much…to be truthful. But Catra didn't seem to like anyone but her…she seemed to tolerate Lonnie and the boys just cause they had been part of the same strike team their whole lives. There was more going on? She was sure of it. But she wouldn't press. Pushing Catra to share

never ended well…so she would be patient. She was good at waiting for Catra to come to her, when she was ready. No matter how long it took.

A heavy silence reigned for a long time, as they each wrestled with the weight of sharing their grief. While Lonnie circled their makeshift monument. Searching for the last departing message. "Kyle…you and Rogelio were supposed to carve Louis's epitaph?" Rogelio growled and snapped his jaws, rising to his feet and slowly approached the tree trunk. He came along Lonnie and pointed upward near the broken crown of branches near the top.

"You have got to be kidding me…that is what Otis wanted to commemorate Louis's life? " Lonnie 's voice screeched in disbelief, then started to laugh softly. By what she found, dangling from the branches of the long dead tree.

Adora slowly raised her eyes, pressing her lips together tight, to stop the fit of fond laughter that wanted to bubble out. While Catra who was far less polite, flopped backwards onto her back cackling loudly. Her bleak mood instantly brightened at the sight.

"What…" Kyle grumped, folding his arms over his chest and pouting indignantly.

Fluttering in the evening wind, from the crown of the deadwood. Was a homemade banner. Tied to the tallest branch of the tree, with a leather string of homemade badges, known in their childhood as 'Shiny's' The trinkets had been fashioned from scrap, by the tiny hands of Louis's friends in the bunkroom. Catra had even made a few for Adora…got into a real nasty fight with Atila over one too. The childish metals shimmering in the dying light of dusk, as the wind spun them. Each one had all meant something to him…

"Is that our War banner?" Catra pointed out, the tattered flag made out of an old gray tarp.

“Yeah…” Adora breathed, a tender smile gracing her lips. As fresh tears formed in her eyes.

“Good times…” Lonnie agreed, examining the tattered tarp with warm, nostalgic shine in her eyes. It was a crudely painted banner with a red horde symbol in the middle, with a smattering of many child sized hand prints of Red Squadron all around it.

“Did we ever find out who won the battle of the barracks?” Kyle offered, taking in the banner with a slow, lingering gaze. His soft blue eyes began to shimmer with a sheen of tears, a faint, bittersweet smile appearing then extinguishing in a matter of moments. As he bowed his head, falling into retrospection.

The banner had been a part of some made up game of war that the junior squadron’s had engaged in. It had been during the cool season, when a freak ice storm had ravaged the Fright Zone. Leaving a thick layer of ice to cover the entire base. All training of cadets had been halted. As the adults and older cadets were tasked to the Fright Zones systems back online. So the kids of the Horde were stuck inside for a whole week, Left unsupervised, with nothing but free time and no adults to boss them around. The children of the barracks, for the first time. Were able to play and just be kids. So many fond memories of skirmishes out in the corridors of the barracks, with one of them charging ahead of the rest of them with that silly banner. As the children of the horde clashed upon some fantasy front line, with nothing more than sticks and their bare hands. Trying to gain ground and win those pretend battles by stealing rival squads banners. Only to retreat to their bunk room at the end of each day, exhausted and fulfilled by their games.

No one answered Kyle, all lost to the memories of a time when they were much younger and far more enthusiastic about their training as soldiers. When they were too young to understand the harsh reality of what the Horde was preparing them for. When they were still just playing at war.

Day Seven

" Catra, We shouldn't do this…" Adora bites her lip, her eyes darting anxiously around their hiding spot. They were hiding behind the boulder again, that jutted out of the edge of the plateau.

"Do you want to walk home?" Catra sniped and rolled her eyes in contempt. Crouching in front of Adora, pressing herself up tight to the rock as she peeked out briefly. Her ears perked up as she listened to the rhythmic crunching of boots on the pebbled beach. The tense, sharp flick of just her tail tip swapping Adora's ankles unconsciously.

A scout patrol from the naval base had pulled up on the beach below on a skiff; the two soldiers were currently investigating their boot prints from yesterday. Their focus was solely upon the ground, pacing in slow circles just below their hiding spot.

Adora wilted just a little under Catra confronting glare, huffing and then sighing as she submitted. She definitely did not want to walk home, it would take days! But stealing a skiff ... .that was risky and they would already be in enough trouble when they got back. Why make it worse?

Electric static echoed from the scouts visored helmets, as the leader relayed his report on the tracks. He paced the short length of the bare shore, between the rocky outcroppings of standing stones that were huddled just below the cliff.

(This is the scout team, Beta, we have found traces of survivors. It looks like at least…a few of those sailor's made it ashore.) The leader had a hand pressed to the side of his helmet, then slowly raised his head to his companion. Who held up five fingers.

(We got five still loose up here.) He finished as the discordant crackle of the base responding, thrummed through the air. They both had their heads down, tracking the boot pints. As they weaved amid the stones and back out onto the beach.

“Well, that’s just great…” Lonnie growled, from her position a few yards away, laying flat within the concealment of tall grass near the edge of the cliff.
“What do we do now…” Kyle whimpered.

“We go on the offensive, we outnumber them and they have no idea where we are. That is to our advantage.” Catra declared in a rough whisper, flashing her fangs in eager anticipation.

Adora’s expression was tense, lips thinned tight. Taking slow breaths to calm her nerves and maintain control over her emotions. Catra was being risky, her plan could get herself or anyone of them killed. Horde soldier’s are trained to shoot first, ask questions later. She needed to reign her in, before she recklessly got them all into danger. But deep down though, she admired her best friend. Catra had a strong, confident air that made you trust in her abilities to lead. Which was one reason Adora had promoted her when they were Sophomores to her Second in Command. As she was able to quickly take in every small detail of their surroundings. Her tactical mind, formulating battle plans effortlessly. It has always been amazing to witness and truth be told, it made Adora feel so inadequate as their leader. Shadow Weaver had put her in charge for some reason, she had seen potential in her. Adora on the other hand, only saw how flawed she was as a leader. Whenever, Catra took charge and completely disregarded her as their Squad Leader. Which in the past had led them to butting heads. Now, after the tragic outcome of her last attempt to lead her squad in battle. Adora was no longer that confident in herself. Causing her to stall from asserting her command, her reluctance to put Catra in her place, was enough for Catra to keep taking charge.

“Lonnie, I need you and Adora to follow behind me. Keep out of sight, until I lure those two loser’s away from the skiff. Then you guys hijack it. I’ll meet you back up here, after I shake them.” Catra ordered, her eyes glinting with excitement.

“We are not stealing a skiff…Catra do you know how much more trouble we are going to get into when we get back. If we hover

up in that.” Adora’s hands were flying desperately, fear at their coming consequences haunting her blue eyes.

“Good thing, we’re not stealing it then.” Catra threw back with a mischievous grin, showing a fang in the corner over her curled lips. “We’re just borrowing it!” She clarified, breaking cover and darting low through the grass down the slope of the plateau. Before Adora could continue to debate or even reach out to stop her.

Adora pressed her hands to her face, groaning in intolerable frustration. As once again, Catra refused to listen to her. If they even survived this encounter. They were all heading towards some very harsh punishments when they got back. This treacherous act was only going to make it worse for all of them.

Adora raised her head up from her hands, when she heard Kyle and Rogelio start to chuckle softly. No doubt the two boys were amused by Catra's cocky antics below. As the magicat baited the two soldier’s effortlessly amid the rocks. Curious, Adora surveyed the rocky shore below, the dull roar of the surf a menacing drone that had her blood pumping with adrenaline. Searching for Catra amid the crags and rutted ledges of crumbling cliffs, her eyes descending into the maze of discarded earth and massive boulder’s. That littered the base of the escarpments, made up of fallen debris as the cliffs eroded over the last thousand years. Cascading like a natural labyrinth towards the patches of stony beaches that jutted out into the surf, along the shoreline.

She finally caught sight of Catra. Back pressed up against a set of jagged rocks, leaning up against each other like the spines of books. Hiding out of view to the two scout’s currently patrolling along the narrow shoreline. Searching for what had drawn them to that spot previously. When they got far enough away from Catra's position, wading into the shallow pools of sea water amid the shoals. Now following the trio’s half submerged tracks from yesterday. She threw another stone off to the left, her aim and the strength of her toss was precise. It sailed off into the natural terraces of eroded sediment in the distance, striking the ground

with a dull thump, followed by a clatter as it rolled down into a crevice. The two scouts darted off in that direction like two dogs playing fetch. Disappearing down a slight decline into a roughly carved ravine that led towards the sea. Catra then broke cover, dashing to another rubble pile to the far east of their location. Moving on the balls of her feet, her strides were long and swift. Light on her feet and instinctively stealthy, Catra was a marvel to watch. Adora was once again drawn to how deadly and elegant she was when in combat. The magicat had her full attention, as Adora's admiring gaze followed her along the jagged coast. As she once again took cover behind a wall of flat granite stone slabs, stacked at odd angles upon each other. Continuing to bait the two soldier's with stones, farther and farther away from their skiff.

With a sudden jolt of fright, Adora snapped her eyes right and left, not seeing Lonnie. Who had just taken off, following orders and not waiting for her.

"Fuck…" Adora snarled, at getting distracted. Crawling away from the boulder and heading after Lonnie. By the time she made it down to the beach, Lonnie was at the skiff. Shuffling around the hovercraft, staring at her feet. Searching for something.

"What's wrong?" Adora panted out of breath. Mentally chastising herself yet again for getting distracted by Catra.

"Slight, hitch in the mission. Squad Leader…the keys are gone." Lonnie huffed.

"Crap!" Adora spat venomously, as she leaped onboard. Her eyes searched the empty deck. As if those keys would just magically appear before her somewhere on worn metal planks.

Lonnie caught sight of the sporadic glinting of light, ricocheting off the maze of hard packed, earthen embankments and standing stones down the beach. Stopping her frantic search long enough to zero in on the incoming threat. She leaped onboard, pulling out her slingshot and loading a pellet.

“We got a friendly inbound at three o’clock.” She announced, pulling back on the sling and cocking the round. “Two hostiles on her tail, literally!” She let the pellet fly and reloaded in seconds.

Adora swallowed hard, looking up. Her blue eyes turned gray and stormy with determination. As her lips thinned into a fierce battle hardened expression. Her right hand strayed to her belt, where her bolo’s hung. She was ready to fight and prepared to defend her friend’s with her dying breath if necessary. She adjusted her stance so she could fling the binding weapon at her adversaries when they got in range.

Both Lonnie and Adora were not prepared to deal with the magicat ‘missile’, now zigging, zagging down the beach on all fours. Avoiding the laser blasts from the scout’s rifles, by the tip of her tail. With the keys to the skiff dangling in her mouth. The Day Moon was high overhead, beating down upon them all. It’s rays, flashing off Catra’s mask and the keys. Making the light reflecting off the metal, bounce manically over the shiny pebbles around her feet and flash sharply like a sudden burst of light when rebounded off the crystal sediment. That was embedded into spiraling seams, within the onyx rock formations guarding her flanks.

Adora was once more transfixed upon her best friend, her eyes wide with wonder. Mesmerized by how wild and untamed Catra truly was. She was so amazing!

No longer constrained by the rules of combat they had been drilled to follow. She was leaning into her true nature once again. Leaping and rebounding off the pillars of stone as she evaded their gunfire. Twisting her slender body in mid-air, as she angled herself effortlessly back towards the ground. Her agility and speed was awe inspiring to watch, her movements fluid and graceful. As she jumped several feet into the air and front flipped to avoid getting blasted. Effortless gaining more ground, as she landed back on all fours and continued to outpace her pursuers.

Lonnie kept laying down cover fire, a lucky pellet knocked a scouts helmet backwards. The scout was instantly subdued,

disorientated; he stumbled and fired towards his companion. Forcing the other scout to duck themselves away behind a pile of boulder’s. Cussing out his friend's incompetence, his arm thrust out of cover a second later and smacked his fellow scout upside the helmet. Causing the shorter scout to drop his rifle, in a desperate attempt to fix his helmet that was now on completely backwards.

Catra glanced over her shoulder, a sly smile gracing her lips. Swiftly covering the open distance of the beach just ahead of the skiff. Spitting the key’s out into her palm and tossed them at Adora, as she leaped aboard.

Adora nodded, hooking her bolo’s back on her belt with one hand, while catching the keys with the other. Than jamming them into the ignition. Cranking the rudder up and to the left. The skiff roared to life and sped away down the beach.

“Let's get the hell out of here! “ Catre screamed urgently. Her pupils were blown, instincts slowly simmering down as she was now out of danger. Her breath was sharp and ragged, chest heaving for air, her heart was pounding against her ribst like a drum.

“Nice moves out there, Soldier!” Lonnie congratulated her. Catra slapped her clawed hand against Lonnie’s in a hearty high five as she passed her. Her tail was high and lashing, her fur once on edge by the danger was slowly easing back down. As she headed towards the side of the skiff. The thrill of combat slowly melted from her overcharged muscles. Now, slinking over to the railing on all fours and sitting down with bright, pleased laughter. That had been her first taste of real combat. She could have died back there if one of those laser blasts hit. The near death experience slammed into her like a sledgehammer, leaving her whole body trembling. Her grin was wide and feral, as she caught her breath. Her mind was a whirlwind, as she reviewed her narrow escape and shocking fact that she had survived…the fast paced intensity of battle was…kinda addicting…she wanted to feel that surge of pure instincts again…as she tempted fate…pushing her body

beyond its limits, running over that razor's edge…between life and death…damn…that had felt so incredible!

The Scouts somberly watched their ride disappear down the shoreline.

"Great…just great…" One scout growled. Tossing a hand towards the retreating skiff in frustration.

The Lead scout was far more observant and calm. Having unlatched his binoculars from his utility belt and pressing them against his visor. Getting a good look at who had stolen the skiff. He watched in what direction the skiff was headed, as it mounted the slope of the seaside cliffs. Headed upward to the plateau.

(This is Beta team…we found the missing cadets…) The lead scout pressed the com button against the left side of his helmet relaying his report to the naval base.

(Acknowledged. Shadow Weaver will be informed. A retrieval unit from the Naval base had been dispatched, the units sent from Fright Zone, have been rerouted towards Scorpion Hills. A transport will intercept.) Was the response from the naval base.

"What about us?" The other scout grumbled.

"We walk." was the second scout's gruff response, shrugging his shoulders and heading away up the rocky shoreline.

By nightfall, the skiff had covered more ground than they had in several days on foot. Adora was at the helm. Her focus was unwavering, as she steered them towards home. Guiding the skiff across the barren wasteland. Skimming the edge of the cavernous, dried out ravine. Headed east, once more following the toxic remains of the stream. The broken crags of the Stinger Mountains looming in the distance. Shielding the monstrous towers of repurposed starships of the Horde Fortress. That lay huddled in the broken cradle of the mountain's curved, granite maw.

“Almost home.” Adora muttered, followed by a sharp intake of breath. A bleak resignation of the inevitable discipline to come. Hung over her, as her shoulders slumped and the furrow of her brow grew more intense. Debating briefly if it had all been worth it? She flinched and snapped her eyes shut, as a gust of hot wind buffeted them.

Catra was once again crouched upon the back engine housing behind Adora. Her chin raised, sniffing the air as a familiar scent accosted her. Ozone, chemical fumes and old oil…her lips curled and her brow furrowed in disgust.

“Sure, smells like it.” She grumbled, licking her teeth in distaste. Before getting overwhelmed. She swung her head away from the fortress and gagged. As the putrid stench once again clogged her throat. Her pupils dilated in sudden fear as she caught sight of light glowing in the distance behind them.

“We got company.” The magicat shouted, pointing towards the flat plains to the west.

Adora snapped her head to the side, hearing the roar of the engines before she caught sight of the shadowed hulk of a troop transport headed straight for them.

“Aw…shit…” Lonnie huffed, from her position leaning casually against the stern railing. Grim resignation is clear in her soft, defeated tone.

Kyle whimpered softly, wringing his hands in his lap. As he was sitting on the deck just beside Lonnie. Rogelio merely stood up, placing a comforting hand on Kyle’s shoulder. As the lizard licked his thin lips and narrowed his eyes with resolve, to remain strong for Kyle. They would get through their coming discipline together. He would make sure of it!

As the transport hovered up behind them. Adora instantly took charge.

“I’ll handle it…You guys just stay silent…alright.” Adora commanded, releasing the rudder. Making eye contact with every one of her strike team, the blue of her eyes had turned to cold steel. The hard, uncompromising stare she shared with each one broached no argument. Even Catra ducked her head slightly, ear’s falling and tail twitched low. Submitting without a fight, by the fierceness in Adora’s gaze.

(Cut your engines and prepare to be taken into custody!) A familiar, deep, gravelly voice exploded from the Transports speaker’s.

Catra yanked the keys out of the ignition, ready to pocket them. Before feeling Adora’s stern, reproachful eyes upon her. Catra rolled her eyes and handed them to Adora, with a begrudging snarl.

“Seriously, Catra…We are in enough trouble as it is.” Adora advised, in a heated, totally exasperated tone. Catra’s insolence was second nature at this point and grated upon Adora. Who just wanted to protect her squad and Catra was already making it more difficult.

“Fine, Whatever…” Catra retorted in a huff, hopping off the engine with a flip and landing on the ground in a crouch.

Adora and the rest disembarked with less grandeur. Merely hoping over the sides to stand at attention with Catra.

The transport came to an abrupt halt, several yards away. The blinding intensity of the large headlights flooding over them. As the ramp slowly eased down from the backend of the hull, with much screaming and grinding. No doubt this piece of equipment was in need of servicing.

The sharp white light from inside the cargo compartment, cut over the ramp. Flooding over the nearby ground, illuminating the red clay surrounding the back of the transport. Catra had to squint to

see who was exiting the vehicle, as the sudden assault of bright light was burning her eyes. Making them water…

She would never admit or even show that she was scared…having endured a lot of varying, mostly rather harsh punishments over the years with all her little rebellion's growing up. But running away for a week was a whole new level…of insubordination for her. She couldn't even fathom what kind of 'correction' might await her at Shadow Weaver's hand. That kind of deep seeded dread was like a ball of ice in her gut. Freezing her insides and burning them at the same time. Needing to control the fear, now coursing through her. She focused on the rapid fire beat of her heart hammering in her chest. Instead of the doom spiral now spinning inside her head. She stood stiff, back straight. All expression drained away from her face. Staring ahead, standing in line beside Adora with the rest of her strike team. Waiting…

Adora cut her eyes to Catra briefly, noticing the trembling in her rigid body. As the small contingent of fully armored soldier's thundered down the ramp. She reached out and hooked her pinky finger with Catra's. A ghost of a smile passed over Adora's face as she heard Catra's gasp and felt the magicat return her reassurance. By curling her pinky finger with Adora's.

Whatever was going to happen…they would get through it together…

"WHAT THE HELL WERE YOU THINKING!" Lazlo marched up to them from behind the contingent of soldiers. Shouting right into Adora's face. Adora flinched slightly, as his spit hit her across the bridge of her nose.

Staff Sergeant Lazlo looked haggard and worn, with heavy bruises of exhaustion under his eyes. He was dressed in gray survival fatigues, with a puffy utility vest and belt. His blue scaly face was flushed with barely contained fury, the short spikes upon his head quivering. Yellow predatory eyes scanned each one of them, as he paced before the team. His lingering gaze was filled with a quiet fury and heavy with disappointment. As he slowly took in each

and every one of them. His thick leather combat boots struck the ground, as he paced. Making the dried clay jump and shiver beneath their feet. Resurrecting that primal fear and heart stopping trepidation, he had instilled in them as small children.

"YOUR SUPERIOR OFFICER WAS GRACIOUS ENOUGH TO GIVE YOU THANKLESS LOT A BIT OF DOWNTIME AFTER WHAT HAPPENED. SO YOU REPAY HER KINDNESS BY GOING AWOL! YOU ARE LUCKY IT WAS ME THAT FOUND YOU.! YOU FIVE DEFECTORS WOULD HAVE BEEN SHOT ON SIGHT BY ANY OTHER RETRIEVAL TEAM! " Lazlo informed them, his words striking the air like gunshots.

Kyle whimpered, biting his lower lip as silent tears began to fall down his cheeks.

Lonnie ground her teeth, holding her own terror in check. As Rogelio shifted forward slightly, remaining at attention but unconsciously seeking to protect his closest friends. As Lonnie was on the verge of tears herself.

Lazlo caught sight of Kyle's tears, taking a long, soothing breath. He chucked a thumb, sharply back at the open transport.

"Inside, NOW!" He commanded with a thunderous roar .

The five cadet's turned on their heels and marched, double time around the back and up the ramp into the cargo hold. Lazlo's soldiers marched in after them. Leaving the Staff Sergeant out in the darkness, staring up at the moon's overhead with a thoughtful, pensive frown. Finally he tapped his badge upon the breast of his vest.

"This is Lazlo, I got them." He informed his superior on the other end of this communication.

"Good, Bring Adora to me. The rest…of those worthless recruits… put them in the reconditioning cells to rot with the rest of their squad. " Shadow Weaver growled over the com's. Her cold displeasure in regards to Adora's, was ominous over the com's.

“As you command.” Lazlo responded, taping his badge to end the call. He shook out his shoulders, in an attempt to shake off the unsettled feelings. Caused by Shadow Weaver’s venomous proclamation. His squadron was going to have to pay a pretty hefty price for what they had done.

The ride back to base was long, uncomfortable and ominously silent. The five cadets knelt in the open cargo hold, hands bound behind their back in metal cuffs. Heads bowed and desperately readjusted their legs as the transport rumbled over the uneven ground. The armored horde soldier’s sat on the metal benches adhered to either side of the hold, rifles trained down upon the small group of cadets huddled between them. The fact that they had been bound and were now being guarded like prisoners of war. Shook all five of them to the core, the seriousness of what they had done finally hitting home and hitting hard.

Lazlo stood at the front of the hold, leaning against the wall beside the narrow window that separated the hold from the cockpit. He had allowed them to marinate inside their own tortured thoughts for a long time, now he wanted answers. He moved swiftly, to crouch in front of Adora. Leaning in low so that he was once more inches from her nose. His sharp movements and close proximity are threatening and a clear form of intimidation.

“Why did you do it…why did you leave?” Lazlo inquired, arms crossed over his chest. Rage, disappointment and confusion, thick in his harsh whisper.

“It was my idea, sir.” Adora responded crisply, not lifting her head. Already prepared to take the blame. Seeking to protect her strike team, to protect Catra.

Everyone else remained silent, even though a low, guttural snarl vibrated from Catra’s chest. Hating how cowardly she was being, by not speaking up. Allowing Adora to sacrifice herself for the squad…for her. Adora always stepped up, she was always the brave one. Always tried to take the fall, when they got in trouble

growing up. It didn't always work, but she never stopped trying to shield Catra from punishment. Adora was their leader and the consequences were always hers to atone for.

"That does not answer my question, Cadet." Lazlo scoffed, knocking Adora on the top of her head with a meaty knuckle. When she didn't raise her head, he pinched her chin with his rough, calloused fingers, forcing her to look up at him. His yellow eyes, pierced into Adora's. Willing her to be truthful, in the hopes that perhaps he could help ease the punishment that lay ahead for her, for all of them.

Adora swallowed several times to quell the waver in her voice before responding.

"My team was just following my orders, sir." She offered, expression blank and devoid of any emotion.

"Do you five even realize how serious what you did was?" Lazlo sighed and stood up. "You left the base without permission…it could be seen as an attempt at defection…or worse you all could be accused of treason. The rest of your squadron has been under interrogation. At first they gave false reports as to your locations. Attempting to stall our efforts at finding you. We sent recon scouts all around the base looking for you, wasting our time and manpower for nearly a week. So they have been incarcerated in the Disciplinary Barracks since you all went missing. " Lazlo sighed, "That's where the rest of you are all headed. "

He waited a moment for that to sink in. Watching as Kyle curled up even tighter, shoulder's quaking as he cried softly. Lonnie glanced at Kyle and Rogelio briefly wondering if either of them would break. They had just wanted freedom even for a little while. To do something meaningful for just them…if Lazlo found out about the real reason they took off. Would he support what they did, or scoff and ridicule them for being so sentimental and weak? Was it worth taking a chance, that their Staff Sergeant would stand up for them? To their superior officer…to Shadow Weaver? Who no doubt would see their efforts to commemorate their fallen

comrades as a waste of time. It might even make her more furious and their punishment ever more severe? So Lonnie remained silent, scowling down at the floor.

Adora's mind quickly weighed the pros and cons of being truthful. In the end, silence won out. It was a well tested and a proven method to avoid enduring worse discipline in the past. It was better to just bow your head and push through the pain to come. It ended eventually…

Once inside the fortress, the transport headed towards the training sector. To the central parade yard, that dominated the heart of the barracks. The transport headed across the open tarmac, the squat, rounded, tin buildings of the barrack's sprawling along the perimeter. The flat cement yard was mostly empty, used for parade marches and open field warfare drills. Where squadrons learned to move in perfectly timed and cohesive movements. Sitting in the center of the tarmac was a solitary, tin and steel structure. Squat and simply constructed, resembling a nondescript box more than a building. With no windows and only one access door. Completely contained and no way to escape once you were inside. Known only as the Disciplinary Barracks. A chain link fence surrounded the bunker, with a heavy iron gate. The small, outer yard was empty, except for guards on patrol along the perimeter outside the fence. It was a prison for cadets… where they would be interrogated and reconditioned before being allowed to return to active duty within the barracks.

Catra was the only one to hear the rattle and clang of the gate pulling aside above the deafening roar of the transport engines. Her ears pinned back and her heart leaped into her throat with renewed dread. Each one of them had their own reasons for leaving. Running away from the Fright Zone, for her. Had been impulsive, spurned by her fear. That her death was going to be just as insignificant as Louis's one day. That she would never accomplish anything, never make a name for herself and prove to Shadow Weaver that she was worth something. Full of rage and fury at how pointless her life truly was. She had wanted Tama's life to have meaning. She wanted others to find the monument

and know that kind hearted, sweet little girl had existed. Her life mattered and that she had been loved. Wanting to get out, to experience freedom and live her life for herself. Before becoming some faceless cog in Hordak's war machine. She hadn't really thought it through…what the consequences might be. That leaving the base was anything more serious than skipping a training session. Now she would be held accountable and she was petrified. Glancing up briefly, she took stock of her strike team. Adora was kneeling beside her, staring at the floor. Her eyes were distant, fogged with tears that she would not let fall.
"It's going to be alright, Catra." She whispered, not looking up. Her words are more wishful thinking than reality. Catra had heard them many times before, when they got caught misbehaving as children. It didn't ease the intensity of fear now coursing through her. As those words never protected her from punishment, it was just a useless platitude. Catra swallowed hard, snapping her eyes to her other side. Finding Rogelio kneeling beside her, the spines down his back and tail were standing up rigid and quivering. Forcing his tattered training shirt to pull back, the fabric straining against his thick chest. The lizard was obviously terrified. Kyle was on the other side of him, staring down at the floor. His blue eyes now strangely unfocused, with a stone cold, blank expression. Pale and shivering, he seemed to have completely disassociated from what was happening. Beside him, Lonnie had her head cocked upward towards the roof of the transport. Hazel eyes blazing with defiance. Mentally fortifying herself for the consequences to come.

The deafening squeal of the brakes sounded, before the bulky transport lurched to a stop. The five bound cadet's grunted and shuffled their legs wide to prevent themselves from being thrown to the floor. Their hearts leaped up into their throats, beating at a frantic crescendo. Each one of them was struggling to breathe. Air puffing out in shallow, sudden gasps as panic set in.

The soldier's hauled them roughly to their feet and led them out of the transport and into the yard. Catra licked her bottom lip, taking a long, lingering look around. The light of the Day Moon was burning upon the horizon. The sliver of sky that was visible

between the barrack compound and the tower's in the distance, turning a radiant red. Tinted to that menacing hue by the chemical's in the air. She lowered her head and chuckled ruefully, at how vile and malevolent the sky looked here in the Fright Zone. Compared to the radiant beauty she had seen out beyond the fortress. It was time to pay for their brief freedom and they would pay for that time in full.

"Come…" Lazlo gruffly pulled Adora aside. She stumbled out of the front of the line.

"Where are you taking her!" Catra shouted, jerking herself free from the soldier who had grabbed her arm.

"She is to be taken to Shadow Weaver." Lazlo answered crisply, hauling Adora out through the open gates and back onto the tarmac. As soon as they passed through, the gate rattled closed.

"Adora!....Adora!...Adora!" Catra writhed in the soldier's iron grip, in some futile attempt to free herself. The level of fear at what Shadow Weaver was going to do to Adora, screaming like a siren in her head. Her fight quickly left her, as she was quickly subdued by another soldier, who pushed his rifle into her back. Then she was abruptly pushed towards the sealed bulkhead. The heavy iron door hissed aside, revealing a set of narrow stairs that led downward into a lightless bunker.

Adora never called back or even looked back. Keeping her head up and resolute to confront Shadow Weaver. Her expression was firm, eyes cold like raw steel. Taking the time allotted to fortify herself to endure the Sorceress wrath.

The trio raised their heads, as they were marched through the door and into the Disciplinary Barracks. Their eyes were hard, resolved to meet their consequences head on. They were not cowards…they were Horde and they would share the burden of punishment with the rest of their Squadron as they always had.

The bunker was dark and damp, like an ancient crypt. The sour smell of defecation and vomit was potent in the stale air. Spot lights flashed on the low roof over their heads as they marched down a solitary, narrow hall. Tiny sealed compartments lined either side of the corridor. The lights just as swiftly dimmed away to darkness as they fell behind them. Each one of them was tossed into a narrow cell, barely large enough to sit in. The cell door slammed closed, the click of the lock sealing them inside was a dreadful sound. Leaving them all in solid black, nothingness. The sudden claustrophobia of feeling the damp walls pressing against your shoulders and back was horrible. It was a hole, a grave to be cast into and forgotten. Once everyone had been ensconced in their own private purgatory. The soldiers departed, their boots faded away down the hall and up the stairs. The hiss of the iron door sealing was the last sound of the real world above that they would hear for a very long time.

It was so much worse than the box…at least that row of adult sized, tin locker's, they had been sealed in. Back in the central training yard inside the barrack compound. As Sophomores and Seniors. Had been on the surface, it had grates. You at least had fresh air and a bit of light. This was like being buried alive!

"Welcome home…" Sara's hoarse voice croaked out from the endless darkness.

Kyle wept, Lonnie screamed and Rogelio howled in fear.

Catra curled up into a tight ball in her cell, arms crossed over her head as if to defend herself from the void that now defined her reality.

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